

A minimalist illustration of a child with dark hair and rosy cheeks, wearing an orange shirt, sitting on a grey stone bench. To the left is a green bush. The background is a light blue sky with two white oval shapes and a green grassy field at the bottom.

THE LITTLE REWRITES

THE ONE WHO SAT ALONE

A story about the new kid, the empty seat, and who we get to become.

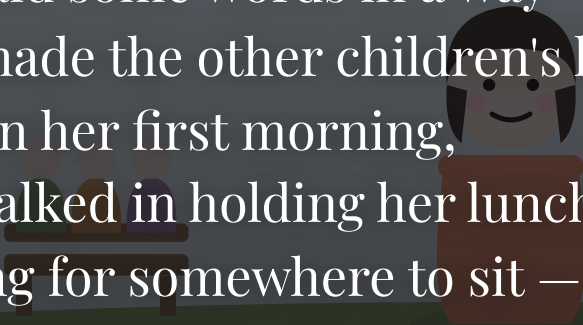
MK PARRISH



When Juniper moved to the town of
Elmsworth,
everything there already had its place.
The birds had their branches.
The shopkeepers had their corners.
And the children had their spots in the
schoolyard —
the same spots they'd had since they were
small,
sorted and settled and sure,
like books on a well-loved shelf.



Juniper had no spot.
She was brand new.
Her clothes were a little different.
She said some words in a way
that made the other children's heads tilt.
And on her first morning,
she walked in holding her lunch,
looking for somewhere to sit —
and every bench was already full
of children who had known each other
their whole lives.

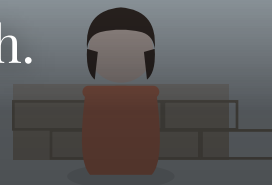


A girl with dark hair and a red shirt is sitting on a low stone wall. The wall has a small set of steps on the right side. The background is a clear blue sky.

So Juniper sat alone,
on the low stone wall
at the very edge of the yard,
and ate her lunch,
and looked like she didn't mind.
She minded terribly.



The children of Elmsworth were not cruel.
They didn't say mean things. They didn't push.
They just... didn't make room.
It's easier not to.



When your shelf is already full and settled,
it's easier to leave the new book on the floor
than to shift everything over to fit it in.

And slowly, the story Juniper told herself
began to change shape,
the way sad thoughts do,
until it became:

maybe there is something wrong with me.

Maybe I am the kind of person who sits alone.

And that is the most dangerous part.

It isn't the empty seat.

It's the story you start to believe
about why it's empty.



Among the children there was a boy named
Cass.

Not the bravest. Not the most popular.

But Cass had noticed the new girl on the wall

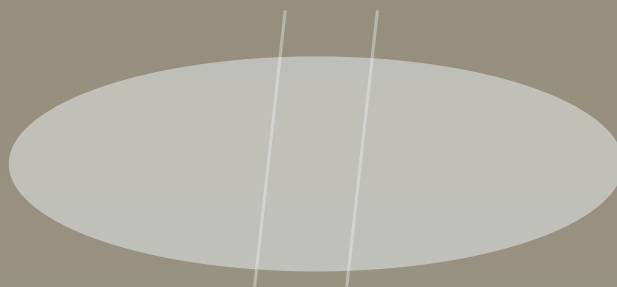
—
the first day, and the second, and the third.

Because Cass had a secret
the others had forgotten:

he had been the new kid once, too.

And he remembered exactly
what the low stone wall felt like.





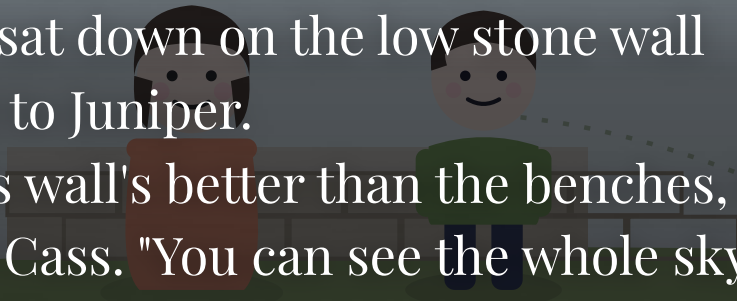
For a whole week, Cass did nothing,
because doing something felt enormous.
What if he walked over
and she didn't want him there?
The wall was only a few steps away.
It might as well have been across the sea.
And then, one gray Thursday,
Cass decided that being a little scared
was a much smaller thing
than letting someone believe
they were the kind of person who sits alone.

So Cass picked up his lunch.
He walked across the yard —
the whole long, terrifying, ordinary way —
and sat down on the low stone wall
next to Juniper.

"This wall's better than the benches, honestly,"
said Cass. "You can see the whole sky from
here."

"You can," said Juniper,
hardly daring to believe it.

"I noticed that too."



And that was all it took.
That was the whole magic.

One kid, a little scared,
choosing to scoot over.

They talked about the sky,
and then about the strange, interesting words
Juniper knew, from a place Cass had never
seen.

Because once one person decides
the lonely kid is worth sitting with,
everybody else suddenly wonders
why they hadn't thought of it first.



Within a month, the low stone wall —
the loneliest spot in all of Elmsworth —
had somehow become the *best* spot.

The spot where the most interesting talk
happened.

And it happened
not because Juniper changed to fit the town,
but because one ordinary boy
changed the town to fit *her*.



The next year, another new child arrived —
small, unsure, clutching a lunch,
heading for the low stone wall.

And Juniper did not wait a whole week.

She did not wait a single day.

She picked up her lunch,
walked across the yard,
and sat right down.

"This wall's the best spot in the whole school,"
Juniper said. "You can see the entire sky from
here.

Want me to show you?"



Everyone is the new kid sometimes.
If that's you right now —
the empty seat beside you
is not proof of anything true about you.
It only means the right person
hasn't scooted over *yet*.
And if you're the one with a spot,
watching someone sit alone:
you can end a whole loneliness
in about ten steps and one sentence.
So pick up your lunch.
Walk across the yard.
Go show them the sky.



FOR THE GROWN-UP READING ALONG

Almost every child, at some point, is the one who sits alone — the new kid, the one who looks or sounds different, the one at the edge of the playground trying to look like they don't mind. This story is for that child, and just as much for the ones who get to decide what happens next. When you finish, ask the child beside you the question the whole book is really about: when you see someone sitting alone, who do you want to be?